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State lawmakers rush to beat deadline

Three weeks left to settle annual budget, Bears stadium fight, battle over spiking insurance rates

By **Jeremy Gorner**
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

SPRINGFIELD — With less than three weeks before the Illinois General Assembly's scheduled adjournment, lawmakers are in a race to finish a multibillion-dollar budget while navigating threats from Washington, a simmering fight over soaring insurance rates, a stadium deal that could decide whether the Bears stay in Illinois and a cascading set of debates over who should pay for it all.

The annual spring sprint before the May 31 scheduled adjournment has interest groups, community advocates and lobbyists flooding

Capitol hallways to claim their share of public dollars. Behind closed doors, lawmakers have been hashing out whether to grant the state more power to block insurance rate hikes, write new rules for driverless cars, lower electric bills inflated by the rise of data centers and clear a path for the Chicago Bears to build a new stadium in Arlington Heights before Indiana lures the franchise across the state line.

Threading through nearly every debate in the Democratic-controlled General Assembly is a fundamental disagreement about the state's fiscal future. While progressive Democrats are pushing to tax billionaires and close corporate

loopholes, Republicans are warning that squeezing job creators will severely damage Illinois' economy. Amid it all is a standoff with the Trump administration, which has signaled it may withhold federal funding from blue states — a threat that could blow a hole in Illinois' finances as soon as next year.

"As I've been out talking to people at town halls and at block club (events) and all those kinds of things, I'm hearing about that issue," state Sen. Elgie Sims, of Chicago, who is the Senate Democrats' chief budget negotiator, said about the issue of affordability. "I hear about it at the grocery store. I hear about it at the gas station. So this budget will continue to make sure that we address those issues because it's

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Illinois state Sen. Bill Cunningham, left, speaks to state Sen. Linda Holmes on the floor of the Senate during resolutions at the Illinois State Capitol Building on Thursday. **EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**



Lindblom Math and Science Academy sophomores Twila Bietila, 15, and Darius Rencher, 17, talk about their experience as co-captains of the school's debate team. They have their eyes on next year's prize: the U.S. National Circuit competition. **JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Always up for debate

The pandemic shrank Lindblom Math & Science Academy's pioneering debate club. Now its ambitious co-captains are trying to build membership and mount a comeback

By **Kate Armanini**
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Darius Rencher and Twila Bietila have a recruitment problem. The teens are the co-captains of the debate team at Lindblom Math & Science Academy in West Englewood, once a powerhouse program, now trying to claw its way back.

"We have a lot of archival clubs," Bietila, 15, said. "We don't like —"

Across the room, debate coach and school counselor Charles Clark sighed. "We love all Lindblom clubs," he cut in. "All Lindblom clubs are great."

(The clubs in question, it turns out, are Model U.N. and the Socialist Club, which apparently draw many of the same students.)

A decade ago, Lindblom had a roster about a dozen strong. Then the pandemic hit, and participation thinned after months of remote learning. The team hasn't

quite recovered its numbers, now hovering around six students. But Rencher and Bietila are mounting a comeback.

Buoyed by a circle of alumni, the sophomores have climbed the ranks of the city's junior varsity debate league. They notched two wins across four tournaments this season, and have their eyes on the next year's prize: the U.S. National Circuit competition. The holy grail of high school debate.

"We would love to have a bigger

team and represent our school," said Rencher, 17, who lives in South Shore.

The team is a chapter of Chicago Debates, which has partnered with Chicago Public Schools for three decades. The nonprofit serves more than 1,600 CPS students each year across 80 middle and high schools, primarily on the South and West sides. It is one of the largest urban policy debate

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Trump rejects Iran's reply to US plan

President offers no details as reports of drones test ceasefire

By **Jon Gambrell**
and **Samy Magdy**
ASSOCIATED PRESS

DUBAI, United Arab Emirates — Iran sent its response to the latest U.S. proposal to end the Iran war via Pakistani mediators on Sunday, but President Donald Trump quickly rejected it in a social media post as "TOTALLY UNACCEPTABLE!" — the latest setback to efforts to resolve the standoff in the Persian Gulf that has throttled shipping and sent energy prices soaring.

Trump's rejection of the Iranian response included no details.

Iranian state television reported that Tehran rejected the U.S. proposal as amounting to surrender, insisting instead on "war reparations by the U.S., full Iranian sovereignty over the Strait of Hormuz, an end to sanctions, and the release of seized Iranian assets."

Washington's latest proposal addressed a deal to end the war, reopen the strait and roll back Iran's nuclear program.

Trump's comments came after CBS' "60 Minutes" released clips from an interview with Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu in which Netanyahu said the conflict with Iran was "not over." He said that was in part because Iran had yet to give up the material that Israel feared could one day be made into a nuclear weapon.

Negotiators for Iran had passed their response to Pakistani mediators, who have been brokering the talks, according to

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INSIDE

Ship passengers to get tests, isolation

Passengers evacuated from a hantavirus-hit cruise ship began flying home aboard military and government planes from the Canary Islands. **Nation & World, B1**

Enrollment falling at US schools

As American women have fewer babies each year, the number of young children is dwindling. The trend is catching up to public school districts. **Nation & World, B2**

Invasive Callery pear trees crowding out natives

Trees once prized for their pretty blooms

By **Jerry Wu**
FOR THE CHICAGO TRIBUNE

When Nikkilyn Morrison moved into her Old Town condo a decade ago, she didn't give much thought to the tall, leafy trees that peeked into her fourth-floor view. Today, she wishes she had.

Last month, her neighborhood became a quiet winter illusion. The dozen trees lining her block burst into clusters of white, creamy flowers. Fallen petals covered the entire street like fresh snow. Then, the smell of rotten fish hit.

"I feel like it makes me almost choke, and I have asthma," said Morrison, who has asked her condo management company about removing the trees. "It kind of makes my lungs seize up too."

The trees on Morrison's block are invasive Callery pears, or Bradford pears, which bloom in blizzards across Illinois neighborhoods, roadsides and forests every April.

For decades, Callery pears were prized for their rapid growth and spring blooms, notwithstanding their noxious odor, but in October the state added the tree to its list of regulated invasive species under the Illinois Exotic Weeds Act. The

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Adam Musto stands among a group of Callery pear trees, an invasive species added under Illinois' Exotic Weed Act last year, at Legion Park in Chicago's West Ridge neighborhood. **BRIAN CASSELLA/TRIBUNE**

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